TECHNICAL REPORT

Implementing Security Features and Governance / Administration Practices in Zoho Creator

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1. Abstract

Zoho Creator lets people build business apps quickly, but an app that holds customer data must also be well protected. This report shows how to configure security and look after an app properly in Zoho Creator. It covers three areas. The first is protecting the sign-in with strong passwords, a second verification step, approved IP addresses and single sign-on. The second is controlling what each person can see and do through permissions, roles and data sharing rules. The third is managing the app over time with test environments, audit trails, backups and regular user clean-up. An insurance claims app serves as the example. The report closes with an action plan, a few limitations and practical tips.

2. Introduction

Low-code tools let one person build and publish an app within days. That speed is useful, but it carries risk. A form collecting names, phone numbers, policy numbers and claim amounts can easily be exposed to the wrong person. A record can be altered without anyone noticing, and an untested change can reach live users. The faster apps are built, the more clear rules matter.

Two ideas matter here. Security means protecting data from people who should not see it, and it answers: who can sign in, from where, and what may they do? Governance means looking after the app over time, and it answers: how are users added and removed, how are changes tested, and how do we keep a record of what happened?

This report describes the tools Zoho Creator provides for both, shows them working together in a real example, and notes the limits an administrator should know.

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3. How Security Works in Zoho Creator

Zoho Creator protects an app in layers, like a building with several locked doors. The first layer decides who may enter, the second decides what a person can do inside, and the third decides which records they can see. A further set of tools helps manage the app itself. Table 1 summarises these layers.

Layer	Zoho Creator Feature	What It Does
Sign-in protection	Security policies (password rules, multi-factor authentication, IP limits, session limits) and single sign-on	Admits only approved users, from approved places
What users can do	Permissions for forms, reports, pages and fields	Controls which parts of the app each person can use
Which records users see	Roles, role hierarchy, peer sharing and data sharing rules	Controls which records each person can see

Layer	Zoho Creator Feature	What It Does
Safe releases	Environments: Development, Stage and Production	Lets changes be tested before real users see them
Monitoring and recovery	Audit trails, automatic backups, app diagnostics	Logs activity and helps recover lost data

Table 1: Layers of security in Zoho Creator

Zoho notes that its permission system gives detailed control over who can view and manage the data in an app. Read and Write are the two default permissions, and custom permissions can grant view, edit or delete access form by form. Zoho recommends combining permissions, role hierarchy and data sharing rules for the best control.

4. Example Application: Insurance Claim Request & Processing Management

4.1 About the App

The example is the Insurance Claim Request & Processing Management app. Its Claim_Request_Form collects the claimant's name, claimant type and policy number, followed by email, phone number and address. It then records the claim type, date of incident, amount requested, supporting documents and a short description. A declaration box confirms that the information is true. One report lists every claim, and the Claims_Dashboard page shows total claims, total and average claim amount, and charts by claim type and claimant type.

Almost every field here is sensitive. Names, phone numbers and addresses identify a person, while claim amounts and descriptions reveal their finances and personal situation. This is why security must be planned carefully for this app.

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4.2 Suggested User Groups

Before changing any setting, list who will use the app and what each person genuinely needs. Table 2 gives a suggested list.

Role	Who They Are	What They Can Access
Administrator	Application owner or IT head	All settings, users and releases; rarely handles claims
Claims Manager	Senior claims supervisor	All team claims; can edit status and approved amounts; sees the dashboard
Claims Officer	Front-line claims staff	Only their own assigned claims; no settings and no exports
Auditor	Compliance or audit officer	Read-only access to reports and the audit trail
Claimant (outside user)	Policyholder or nominee	Can submit a claim and view only their own claim

Table 2: Suggested user groups for the claims app

5. Setting Up Security Features

5.1 Sign-In Protection with Security Policies

Security policies in Zoho Creator work through Zoho Directory. They let an administrator require strong passwords, switch on multi-factor authentication (MFA), allow sign-in only from approved IP addresses and set session time limits. Zoho states that security policies are available only on paid plans, which matters if you are using a trial or free account.

A good starting setup for the claims app is:

- **Strong passwords.** Set a minimum length and a mix of letters, numbers and symbols.
- **Multi-factor authentication.** Ask for a second check when signing in. Start with Administrators and Claims Managers.
- **IP restrictions.** Allow staff to sign in only from the office network or company VPN. Then a stolen password alone is not enough.
- **Session limits.** End idle sessions quickly and limit how many sessions a user can have open. This protects data if someone leaves a computer unlocked.

One tip from Zoho's guide: if a user has allowed one IP address in their own account while the security policy allows a different one, only the policy's address works. Test every policy with a spare account first so nobody is locked out.

5.2 Single Sign-On and Directory Connection

Some organisations already keep staff accounts in another system. Zoho Directory can use that system for single sign-on (SSO) through SAML, so users do not need a new password. It can also connect to Active Directory or LDAP through a sync tool. This helps in two ways: users have one login to remember, and when a person leaves and their main account is switched off, their access to Zoho Creator ends at the same moment.

5.3 Permissions for Forms, Reports and Fields

Permissions decide what a signed-in user can do. At module level, the administrator chooses which forms, reports and pages a person can open. At field level, the administrator chooses which fields a person can view and which they can edit. For example, a Claims Officer may open the claims report but may not change the Policy_Number after submission, while an Auditor may view every field but change none.

Table 3 shows how this could look in the claims app. These values are a suggested design, not a finished setup.

Part of the App	Claims Officer	Claims Manager	Auditor	Claimant
Claim_Request_Form (submit)	Yes	Yes	No	Yes

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Part of the App	Claims Officer	Claims Manager	Auditor	Claimant
Claim_Request_Form Report	Assigned only	Team claims	All, read-only	Own claim only
Claims_Dashboard	Summary only	Yes	Yes	No
Contact and address fields	View, edit	View, edit	View	Own only
Claim_Amount_Requested	View only	View, edit	View	Own only
Delete records	No	No	No	No
Export data	No	Team only	Reports only	No

Table 3: Suggested permission table

This follows the rule of least privilege: give each person only the access they need. No one can delete records, so nothing disappears quietly. Corrections are made by editing, and the audit trail records each edit.

5.4 Roles and Role Hierarchy

Permissions say what a person can do. Roles say where the person fits in the organisation, which lets you copy your company structure into Creator. When role hierarchy is turned on, a person higher up can see their own records and those added by the people below them. In the claims app, a Claims Manager would see the claims entered by their officers, while each officer would not see their colleagues' claims.

Creator can also share data between peers, so people at the same level can see one another's records. Enable this only when the team really needs it, since it makes more data visible.

5.5 Data Sharing Rules

Real organisations do not always follow a strict ladder, so data sharing rules handle the exceptions. A rule shares the records of a report from one user or role to another. Zoho says these rules override the role hierarchy. For example, a Fraud Review role could be given only the high-value claims, no matter who entered them.

Sharing rules add access; they never remove it. So every rule should have a reason, an owner and a review date. A rule created for a one-time check and then forgotten is a common cause of accidental exposure.

5.6 Protecting Personal Information

The permissions area has settings for fields marked as personal information (PII) or health information (ePHI). The administrator can choose whether these marked fields are visible by default or whether their visibility cannot be selected. In the claims app, contact details, address and policy number would be marked as sensitive. New roles then start with these fields hidden and gain access only when it is clearly needed.

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6. Administration and Governance Practices

6.1 Environments and Safe Releases

Creator's Environments feature gives a safe path for changes. The app is edited in Development, tested in Stage, and then published to Production, where real users work. Each environment keeps its own data, so test records never mix with real claims. Table 4 explains the three stages.

Environment	Purpose	Typical Work
Development	The only place where the app is edited; it can also be opened for early testing	Building forms, reports, workflows and permissions
Stage	Testing changes before release to users	Checking roles, workflows and permissions with demo users
Production	The live app used by real users	Daily claim handling

Table 4: Environments in Zoho Creator

This matters for security, because a permission change can also go wrong. Testing a new role in Stage first stops a mistake from exposing real claim data. Zoho lists two limits. Creator cannot hold more than 30 versions at once in Stage across all apps, so versions must be moved on to Production. Also, approval workflows and data sharing with specific users cannot be tested in Development or Stage, so take extra care when releasing them.

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6.2 Audit Trails

An audit trail is a time-ordered record of what users did in the app. Each entry shows who performed the action, what it was, when it happened and which data it touched. In a claims system it answers questions such as who changed a claim amount and when a status was edited.

Keeping the record is only half the job; someone must read it. An administrator or auditor should review it on a regular schedule, for example every week for changes to amounts and statuses, and immediately after any security incident.

6.3 Backups, Diagnostics and Updates

Creator makes automatic backups of app data, offers app diagnostics to keep apps running well, and applies new features and security fixes automatically. This lowers the vendor-side workload, but the administrator still has jobs to do: know how to request a restore, confirm that restores work, and test key forms and reports after each update.

6.4 Managing Users Over Time

Many security problems come from people, not technology. Old accounts are never removed, or permissions slowly grow. A simple routine prevents this:

- **New user:** give the role that matches the job, and nothing extra.
- **Job change:** change the role instead of adding a new one on top.

- **Person leaves:** switch off the account the same day, ideally through the central directory.
- **Every two months:** review users, roles and sharing rules, and remove what is not needed.

6.5 Domain and Email Safety

Creator uses domain authentication so that only genuine domains can access the app. It also supports the email checks SPF, DKIM and DMARC. This matters because the claims app sends emails to claimants: these checks help real emails reach the inbox and make fake emails harder to pass off as yours.

7. Step-by-Step Implementation Plan

Table 5 turns these ideas into an ordered plan. The basics, users and roles, come first, before any real data is added or any real users are invited.

Step	Action	Where in Creator	Result
1	List user groups and the data each one needs	Planning document	Agreed roles (Table 2)
2	Set security policy: passwords, MFA, IP limits, timeouts	Security policies (Zoho Directory)	Secured staff sign-in
3	Connect the identity provider, if there is one	SAML single sign-on or directory sync	One login per person
4	Create roles and turn on role hierarchy	Users and roles	Managers see their own team's records
5	Set permissions for forms, reports and fields	Permissions	Least-privilege access (Table 3)
6	Add data sharing rules only for exceptions	Data sharing rules	Documented exceptions with owners
7	Test everything in Stage with demo users	Environments	Verified before release
8	Publish to Production and start audit checks	Environments, audit trail	Live app under monitoring
9	Review users, rules and logs every two months	Admin routine	Access stays accurate

Table 5: Implementation plan

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8. Challenges and Limitations

A fair report should also say where these tools need care or fall short.

- **Plan limits.** Security policies need a paid plan. On a trial account, MFA and IP restrictions may not be available.
- **Testing gaps.** Approval workflows and sharing with specific users cannot be tested in Development or Stage, so part of the access setup is only checked after release.

- **Rules that overlap.** Permissions, role hierarchy, peer sharing and sharing rules affect each other. Because sharing rules override the hierarchy, a wrong mix can give someone too much access. Test each change with a user who has that role.
- **Depending on the vendor.** Zoho handles backups, patches and upgrades. This is convenient, but proof for auditors must come from Zoho's documents. Check Zoho's published compliance and data-location details instead of assuming.
- **Human mistakes.** No setting stops someone from sharing a password or saving data on a personal device. Training and clear rules are also needed.

9. Best Practices and Recommendations

- **Plan access first.** Decide roles and sensitive fields before building forms.
- **Give least access.** Start with little and add more only when asked.
- **Protect administrators most.** Require MFA for every administrator and keep their number small.
- **Never test in Production.** Change in Development, check in Stage, then publish.
- **Write down every exception.** Note the reason, owner and review date for each special rule.
- **Read the audit trail regularly.** Give the task to a named person and a fixed schedule.
- **Remove leavers quickly.** Switch off accounts on the last working day.
- **Check Zoho's evidence.** Read the current security and compliance pages before storing regulated data, and keep a copy.

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10. Conclusion

Zoho Creator gives administrators layered tools to protect apps and manage them well. Security policies, MFA, IP limits and single sign-on protect the sign-in. Permissions, roles and sharing rules control what each person can do and see. Environments, audit trails and backups keep the app organised and accountable. The claims app example shows these tools work best when planned together: decide roles first, give the least access, test before release, and review activity often.

Even so, tools alone are not enough, because plan limits, testing gaps, overlapping rules and human mistakes remain. Organisations that treat security as a continuing habit rather than a one-time setup can enjoy the speed of low-code without putting their data at risk.

11. References

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